

drives and its orange-silver combination doesn't give it a pleasing look.

Portability

Although there is no compulsion for desktop drives to be compact, they shouldn't be overly bulky. Thankfully, none sported dimensions which discouraged them from being carried along as portable drives. Most of these drives tipped the scales at well over 1 kg — they are heavy to carry around. LaCie's Rugged, with its aluminium alloy enclosure, was the lightest drive at just 250 grams.

Interface

For desktop drives, the type of interface matters; USB is de-facto, but exotic interfaces such as eSATA, Ethernet and FireWire are must haves. Drives with Ethernet should be preferred if you want to hook them directly to your network. eSATA comes in at second but requires a compatible PC. FireWire is great when you have a Macintosh. Verbatim came with just a USB port, LaCie managed to cramp in USB, FireWire 400 and 800 ports but missed out on eSATA. The Western Digital My Book Essential comes with the omnipresent USB, but WD was smart enough to lace its Studio drive with USB, two FireWire 800 and an eSATA port. Freecom's network drive, as the name suggests, came with an Ethernet and USB port.

Bundle

Almost all drives in this category were bundled with the right cables as per the interface provided. All drives need external power and a power adapter comes bundled with all of them. Since desktop drives will be used for backup, all drives were bundled with backup applications. NTI shadow, Nero backup, One-click backup, etc., were bundled with Freecom, Verbatim and LaCie drives respectively. Western Digital has the WD Sync tool bundled and the Studio version of My Book comes with MioNet; online personal network for remote access of drives.



Western Digital
My Book Studio
1 TB

Performance

The LaCie Rugged drive was hooked up using the FireWire 800 port and it blasted the rest of the drives into oblivion, delivering terrific performance figures. CPU utilisation was kept in check and it never went over 1 per cent — simply superb; all other drives were in the 4 to 8 per cent range. Western Digital's Studio 1 TB comes in at second place, again thanks to the use

of a FireWire bus. The Freecom Network drive was tested using the USB interface and hence it comes at third spot. When we put it on a network, the performance figures were simply terrific. In terms of sheer performance, LaCie reigned.

Conclusion

With features, performance and price per GB put together Freecom's Network Drive comes top. Ethernet connectivity, good performance and low price per GB gives the Freecom Network drive an edge over Western Digital's My Book Studio. But, if you need loads of space (one TB), choice of interface, relatively low price per GB then the WD My Book Studio should be high on your list. LaCie's Rugged 500 GB makes a good buy if you want 500 GB in a portable form factor. ■

sanket.naik@thinkdigit.com



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